

FAQ

We fully support building a new Winter Hill school ASAP. Won't advocating for 690 seats slow down the already frustratingly slow process further?

Absolutely not. The city is working to fund a portion of the new building with MSBA dollars — though the effective reimbursement rate after ineligible costs are excluded is typically well below the nominal rate, meaning Somerville taxpayers will fund the majority of the building cost.

The MSBA has a very strict process and timeline, which the city has diligently followed. The current stage is called the Feasibility Study, which requires the city to develop multiple options in parallel. While 925 seats is the city's preferred option, developing the 690-seat option alongside it is a formal MSBA feasibility study requirement: the MSBA's own guidance directs that the preliminary evaluation of alternatives be comprehensive enough in scope to consider all possible solutions, so that the Feasibility Study can identify the most cost-effective and educationally appropriate option that the community and the MSBA Board can support.

You can see both options developed in detail in the March 2nd School Building Committee materials [here](#).

What happens to the Brown School in the future if we rebuild a smaller school now?

Under the 690-seat model, the Brown School remains open. The district retains the flexibility to absorb Brown's approximately 230 students into the new Winter Hill building in the future — including through the middle school grades — but only after the School Committee has completed the process that closing a neighborhood school actually requires.

Somerville's own Policy FCB requires a formal closing study before any school building is decommissioned — with direct neighborhood involvement and documented analysis of reassignment plans, alternative uses, and cost implications. None of this has been done for the Brown School.

The 925-seat option makes Brown's closure a condition of state funding before any of these policy requirements have been met, and before the School Committee has formally voted to close the school. The 690-seat option preserves the community's ability to demand that process happen properly and in the right order.

I'm not sure the Brown School should stay open with the challenges it faces. What about that?

That's a fair concern. Building a 690-seat school gives the public a genuine opportunity to engage with the School Committee about Brown's future — including its ADA accessibility

challenges, equity implications, and how any improvements might be financed — before closure becomes a foregone conclusion.

Building a 925-seat school forces Brown's closure as a condition of accepting MSBA funding, with no public engagement and no answers to the questions Somerville's own Policy FCB requires be addressed before any school is closed. The 690-seat option keeps those conversations open.

Does the city have a solution for the additional traffic and parking needs a 925-seat school will introduce?

Not yet. The presentation to the School Building Committee from June 9, 2026 [\[LINK\]](#) reveals that the design team is still actively working through how traffic and parking will function at the 925-seat school, with no clear solution in sight:

Medford Street — the main arterial road adjacent to the site — has been ruled out for drop-off and pick-up due to rush hour traffic Sycamore Street, the primary drop-off zone, may need to be closed to parents entirely during school hours The design team is considering a numbered vehicle display system with advance spotters to manage student pick-up — logistics typically associated with large suburban schools, not urban neighborhood schools Even cycling presents challenges: the uphill grade on Sycamore makes biking difficult for families

None of this has been communicated to the broader community. The city's public FAQ does not address traffic and parking at all — deflecting the question to "the City of Somerville" as if SPS and the City are separate entities on this issue.

The city says a redistricting plan will be ready "by Fall 2026". What's the problem with that?

The Preferred Schematic Report (PSR) — the state submission that formally recommends the 925-seat option to the MSBA — is due in August 2026, before Fall. The community will not see a redistricting plan before that recommendation is made.

The MSBA also requires the district to submit a Grade Reconfiguration and Districting Approval Certification as part of the PSR. This certification requires documented public meetings specifically about redistricting, held in compliance with Open Meeting Law. No such meetings have been scheduled. The district's own stated timeline makes it unclear how that certification requirement can be satisfied by August.

The city says research doesn't show an advantage for smaller schools. Is that accurate?

The city makes this claim without citing any sources. A [2015 Hanover Research review](#) of the school size literature finds the opposite: smaller schools consistently produce equal or better academic outcomes, with additional benefits including improved student behavior, higher attendance, fewer dropouts, and more positive teacher attitudes. These effects are

strongest for low-income and minority students — exactly the population Somerville serves. The city's answer also doesn't address walkability, operating costs, or sense of belonging — even though the city's own 2025 CAG survey found Somerville residents prioritize walkability above all else regardless of which school option they prefer.

Winter Hill and Brown are small schools with 2 classrooms per grade. The city says the 925-seat building will feel like a small school because of internal grade clusters. Is that right?

The clustering model — organizing students into PK-3, 4-6, and 7-8 groups within the building — is formally known as Small Learning Communities (SLCs). But there are two problems with applying it here.

First, SLCs were developed as a reform strategy for large secondary schools, not elementary schools. Both ASCD's review and a University of Michigan Ford School panel on school size reform address SLCs specifically in the high school context, and even there the evidence is mixed: ASCD's review concludes that no single clustering strategy has a demonstrated track record at scale, and that whether it succeeds depends on the specific student population and the faculty's interests and expertise.

Second, clustering changes how floors are organized — it doesn't change how many kids are in the building. At 925 seats, there will be 4 to 5 classrooms per grade. At 690 seats, 2 to 3. That difference determines whether the principal knows every student by name, whether kids know everyone in their grade, whether families feel like part of a community rather than one of hundreds. These are the things Brown and Winter Hill families value about their current schools, and they depend on actual school size, not what the clusters are called.

Can the 690-seat proposal address any current issues the Brown School faces?

One significant issue it can address: the stressful 6th grade transition. Right now, Brown is K-5, which means every Brown family faces a middle school lottery every year, competing for 6th grade spots at Kennedy and West Somerville Neighborhood School — both already at or near capacity. The new 690-seat Winter Hill building would be PK-8, with enough middle school capacity to accommodate current Winter Hill students plus all Brown 5th graders going into middle school, giving Brown families a clear, predictable path to middle school without Brown having to close.

The walkability calculus shifts at the middle school level, since the City of Somerville already assumes students transition to public transit by then, as evidenced by all Somerville students receiving a free MBTA pass starting in grade 7; this is distinct from the elementary-level walkability loss discussed below, which affects younger children who are not expected to use public transit independently and whose families have fewer transportation alternatives.

Do you support the debt exclusion vote to fund the Winter Hill School? How does school size affect what I'll pay?

We fully support a debt exclusion vote to fund a new Winter Hill school, and we want it to pass. The question is what Somerville residents are being asked to fund, and at what cost.

The city's April 2026 Preliminary Design Program submission puts early construction cost estimates at \$174.5-\$177.6 million for the 690-seat option and \$184.9-\$193.5 million for the 925-seat option, before MSBA reimbursement. The document itself acknowledges the scale of this cost, noting that the size of the investment is leading the city to seriously consider a Proposition 2½ Debt Exclusion Ballot Measure.

After reimbursement — which based on comparable projects will leave Somerville taxpayers funding the majority of the total cost — a larger building means a larger debt exclusion and higher property taxes. Higher property taxes also translate directly into higher rents for the many Somerville residents who don't own property.

The city has not published a complete cost comparison between the two options, including MSBA reimbursement, net taxpayer cost, long-term operating costs, and the cost of adaptive reuse of the Brown building under the 925-seat scenario. That comparison should exist before residents are asked to vote in 2027.

How many families will lose their walkable elementary school option, and what does this mean for traffic and the city's transportation budget?

No one knows — because the city hasn't published a walkability analysis by catchment area. That analysis should exist before a decision of this magnitude is made.

The city's response acknowledges that closing Brown "will affect student assignment and family choice across the district" and that changes could impact "access to neighborhood and walkable school options." But it commits only to a timeline for reviewing assignment policy — by Fall 2026, after the PSR deadline. Notably, the community asked specifically about walkable school options. The city's stated goal is "realistic school options," not walkable ones.

The city has committed to "prioritizing Brown and Winter Hill families for placement in the new school." Prioritizing is not guaranteeing, and it says nothing about families who prefer a west side school, or what happens to west side capacity as the Clarendon Hill redevelopment adds 591 new housing units directly next to WSNS.

Under current SPS transportation policy, the district buses students between their proximity school and their assigned school; families are responsible for the first leg. If Brown closes, west side families' proximity school becomes WSNS or Kennedy, both significantly closer to home than 115 Sycamore. Kennedy is 1.7 miles from the new Winter Hill; WSNS is 2 miles away. Families redistricted to Sycamore would need to get their children to WSNS or Kennedy first, then rely on a district bus to 115 Sycamore. Many will

choose to drive directly instead, adding cars to a one-way residential street where the design team has already identified significant traffic challenges, in direct contradiction of the city's own Vision Zero and climate commitments.

The city has not published how many families lose walkable access, what additional busing costs consolidation would require, or how those costs compare to any operating savings from closing Brown. These are answerable questions that deserve answers before August 2026.

What alternative uses for the Brown School building have been explored, and will it remain in public ownership?

No alternative use analysis has been published. Somerville's own Policy FCB requires such an analysis — covering alternative uses, cost savings, and continuity of community programs — before any school building is decommissioned. It has not been done for Brown.

The Brown School building is publicly owned. Somerville's track record with former school buildings is not reassuring: the Powderhouse Community School sat vacant for over a decade after closing in 2004, going through multiple failed redevelopment proposals before eventually being redeveloped. The city has provided no transparency about what it envisions for the Brown building — whether it would be sold, repurposed, or left vacant — nor what any of those options would cost.

The 925-seat option makes all of these questions moot before they have been asked. The 690-seat option keeps them open.